

Introduction

The University of Transkei (UNITRA) currently Walter Sisulu University, has a rich history of fostering musical talent through its choir, the UNITRA Choir. Over the years, the choir was a source of pride for the university and the surrounding community, taking part in various local and national music festivals and competitions, as well as participating in the university's graduation ceremonies. As former choir members, we feel a profound connection and responsibility to uphold the legacy of the UNITRA Choir. Considering this, we have established the University of Transkei Choir Legacy, to be known as UNITRA Choir Legacy.

Who are we?

The UNITRA Choir Legacy seeks to institutionalize and enhance the yearly reunions of former University of Transkei Choir members, transforming these gatherings into a dedicated non-profit organization. This organization is committed to preserving the esteemed legacy of the UNITRA Choir by engaging in local and international music festivals and highlighting the choir's historical importance.

Our Beneficiaries

- Walter Sisulu University – the collaboration between the UNITRA Choir Legacy and Walter Sisulu University aims to enhance the reputation of the University through initiatives such as music training for identified individuals from historically disadvantaged backgrounds.
- Schools around Mthatha more especially rural communities – the UNITRA Choir Legacy to participate in the ongoing traditional festival in the Eastern Cape, contributing to the transformation of raw talent into professional talent.

Mission

To ensure the enduring legacy of the UNITRA Choir.

Vision

To be a leading non-profit organization in the promotion of choral music, inspiring future generations and honoring the legacy of the UNITRA Choir.

Historical Background

The UNITRA Choir was established in 1987 and significantly promoted choral music in South Africa, particularly among universities. It enriched the country's cultural landscape by attracting members from the University of Transkei's diverse academic disciplines and all Faculties (Arts, Law, Science, Health Sciences, Education, and Economic Sciences). The choir became a unifying force for student activism, providing musical education and instilling ethical values and mutual respect among its members. Through the choir's initiatives, choral music became a vital component of the university experience.

Purpose and Objectives

The main objective of the UNITRA Choir Legacy is to preserve and promote the legacy of the choir through participation in the following activities:

- Ensure the legacy of the UNITRA choir endures by engaging actively in music festivals at both local and international levels.
- Partner with the University of Transkei Alumni Committee to enhance the promotion of the university's cultural initiatives by collaborating with the current Walter Sisulu University choir.
- To reinvest in the community through initiatives focused on social responsibility, scholarships, training and development of conductors, development of opera singing professionals, music facilitators, adjudicators, and similar roles.
- Form partnerships with Jazz Against Apartheid, other creative arts organizations such as indigenous performing groups and Jazz in Africa, as well as jazz artists, to promote and strengthen the Chora-Jazz genre in the Eastern Cape.

Achievements and Contributions

Throughout its existence, the UNITRA Choir developed a distinguished reputation rooted in its devout and family-centered principles. It took part in various local concerts and competitions, including the South African Tertiary Institution Choral Association (SATICA), Transkei Choral Music Association (TRACA), and Old Mutual National Choir Festival, consequently gaining national recognition.

A notable achievement was in 1995 when the choir engaged in cultural exchanges with Germany, including training at the Richard Wagner Music Festival. This opportunity not only contributed to the creation of an archive of African music but also enhanced the choir's standing on the international stage.

Organizational Structure

The operational framework of the UNITRA Choir Legacy will be established as follows.

- The Board is composed of five directors and patrons who serve as Non-Executive Directors.
- Executive Committee - Consisting of elected former UNITRA Choir members, this group will manage the operations and activities of the organization. Essential roles within the organization include Chairperson, Secretary, Treasurer, and Public Relations Officer.
- Sub-committees - Distinct subcommittees will be established to address various areas, including event planning, fundraising initiatives, and alumni engagement.
- UNITRA Choir Legacy - All individuals who were previously members of the UNITRA Choir since its establishment are eligible to join the organization, UNITRA Choir Legacy, and are required to pay a non-refundable monthly membership fee of R300. Members will have the opportunity to engage in decision-making processes and participate in various activities.
- Associate members - Membership shall be open to individuals who do not sing, referred to as Associate Members (AMs). Associate Members will enjoy the same privileges and benefits as singing members and are required to pay a non-refundable monthly membership fee of R300. Additionally, they are expected to participate in sub-committees of the UNITRA Choir Legacy.

Implementation Plan

1) Establishment

Establish a governing board and create the essential legal and administrative structure required to recognize the UNITRA Choir Legacy as a non-profit organization.

2) Event Planning

Arrange gatherings, musical events, and participation in festivals biennially.

The first cultural festival is set to take place at the main campus of Walter Sisulu University (formerly known as the University of Transkei). This occasion will signify the beginning/launch of the UNITRA Choir Legacy.

The upcoming cultural festival will take place in South Korea, with the date contingent upon the financial liquidity of the non-profit organization.

3) Marketing

Create promotional materials and establish a digital presence to enhance event visibility and foster engagement with the wider community.

Resources and Budget

The sustainability of the UNITRA Choir Legacy will primarily depend on member contributions, with a minimum non-refundable amount of R300 per month.

Additionally, it will seek alternative funding sources through charitable donations, sponsorship arrangements, and various fundraising efforts to support its operations.

A comprehensive financial strategy will be established to guarantee transparency and accountability in the handling of financial resources.